

Outlook Management: “Subjective” Meanings of Discourse-Sensitive Adverbs and Particles

Yusuke Kubota

National Institute for Japanese Language and Linguistics

February 11, 2026

1 Introduction

Among Japanese adverbs and focus particles, we can identify subclasses that express some sort of subjective evaluation meanings (see Morimoto 1988; Sawada 2018; Noda 2019 for references accessible in English). Representative items are listed under (1) and (2). The goal of this chapter is to examine the semantic and pragmatic properties of these adverbs and particles by building on both descriptive and theoretical studies, and to suggest ways in which analyses of such expressions can profitably contribute to the development of a formal theory of discourse in natural language.

(1) Adverbs

- a. *dōse* ‘anyway’, *shosen* ‘anyway’, *yahari* ‘after all’, *kekkyoku* ‘after all’ [Morimoto 1994; Takeuchi 2015]
- b. *masani* ‘precisely’, *mushiro* ‘rather’, *mashite* ‘let alone’, *semete* ‘at least’ [Kudo 1977]
- c. *yoppodo* ‘rather’, *kaette* ‘rather’ [Sawada 2010]

(2) Focus particles

- nanka* ‘anything like’, *kurai* ‘at least’, *koso* ‘precisely’ [Numata 1986; Sawada 2007; Ido 2023]

As the rough glosses in (1) and (2) may suggest, many of these words express meanings that can be descriptively categorized as “low evaluation,” “minimum standard,” “emphasis,” or “contrary.” In simple sentences like (3), the owner of such judgments is the speaker of the sentence.

- (3) a. *Watashi-ni-wa dōse kinmedaru-wa tor-e-nai.*
I-DAT-TOP anyway gold.medal-TOP take-POT-NEG
‘I can’t win a gold medal anyway.’
- b. *Watashi-ni-wa kinmedaru nanka tor-e-nai.*
I-DAT-TOP gold.medal NANKA take-POT-NEG
‘I can’t possibly win (anything like) a gold medal.’

In (3a), the adverb *dōse* signals that the speaker has a pessimistic, almost defeatist attitude toward the possibility of winning a gold medal. The focus particle *nanka* in (3b) has a similar

discourse function.

The same type of examples can be constructed with the other adverbs and focus particles in (1) and (2):

- (4) a. *Semete ocha-o non-de it-tara?*
least tea-ACC drink-GER go-if
'(I don't mean to keep you too long, but) why don't you at least have some tea before you go?'
- b. *Ocha-kurai non-de it-tara?*
tea-KURAI drink-GER go-if
'(I don't mean to keep you too long, but) why don't you have something light, like some tea, before you go?'
- (5) a. *Masani kimi-ga iku-beki-da.*
exactly you-NOM go-should-COP
'It is precisely you who should go.'
- b. *Kimi-koso iku-beki-da.*
you-KOSO go-should-COP
'It is you who should go.'
- (6) a. *Sunao-ni misu-o mitome-ta hō-ga mushiro inshō-ga yoi.*
honestly mistake-ACC admit-PAST way-NOM rather impression-NOM
good.
'Frankly admitting your mistake actually leaves a better impression.'
- b. *Sunao-ni misu-o mitome-ta hō-ga yoppodo inshō-ga yoi.*
honestly mistake-ACC admit-PAST way-NOM much.more impression-NOM
good
'Frankly admitting your mistake leaves a far better impression.'

Before moving on, I would like to note that this chapter deals with only a subset of words that express “subjective” meanings in natural language. More prototypical examples of subjective expressions are perhaps evaluative adverbs/adjectives such as *zannennagara* ‘regrettably’ in (7) (see, e.g., Sawada 1978; Kubota 2015) and predicates of personal taste such as *oishii* ‘tasty’ in (8), which directly express evaluative judgment. The status of subjectivity in these types of words has been extensively discussed in the literature of formal semantics and philosophy of language (cf. Stephenson 2007; Lasersohn 2017, among others).

- (7) a. *Tarō-ga fugōkaku dat-ta no-wa zannen da.*
 Taro-NOM failure be-PAST NOM-TOP regrettable COP
 ‘That Taro failed is regrettable.’
- b. *Zannennagara, Tarō-wa fugōkaku dat-ta.*
 regrettable Taro-TOP failure be-PAST
 ‘Regrettably, Taro failed.’
- (8) a. *Kono ocha-wa oishii.*
 this tea-TOP tasty
 ‘This tea is tasty.’
- b. *Kono ocha-o Tarō-wa oishiku non-da.*
 This tea-ACC Taro-TOP tasty-ADV drink-PAST
 ‘Taro drank this tea with pleasure (found it tasty).’

Compared to the words in (7) and (8), which encode specific subjective evaluation meanings, the meanings of the adverbs and focus particles listed under (1) and (2) are more abstract and much harder to pin down precisely. For this reason, I take them to form a distinct semantic class. As a first step in making sense of the meanings and functions of these expressions, we can make some informal observations about the properties they have in common. Note first that these words impose certain constraints on the prior discourse. For example, in the case of *nanka*, the sentence cannot be uttered out of the blue but is felicitous only in a context such as the one in (9), in which the question that the sentence addresses is already at issue in the discourse.

- (9) A: I think you have a good chance of winning a gold medal at the next Olympics if everything goes well.
- B: *Iya-iya, watashi-ni-wa kinmedaru nanka tor-e-nai-desu.*
 No-no I-DAT-TOP gold.medal NANKA take-can-NEG-POL
 ‘I can’t possibly win (anything like) a gold medal.’

In (9B), *nanka* signals the speaker’s negative response toward an overly optimistic prospect that is salient in the discourse, in this case explicitly brought up by A’s immediately preceding utterance. There is a sense in which the use of *nanka* indicates the speaker’s *outlook* on how their own stance, embodied by the propositional content of the sentence, relates to a “counterstance” salient in the discourse context. Other items in (3)–(6) explicitly signal similar outlooks on the part of the speaker. For this reason, I call adverbs and focus particles in (1) and (2) *outlook markers* in what follows, following Kubota and Ido (2026a,b). The term “outlook” is due to Coppock (2018), and in the original formulation it embodies one way of formalizing subjectivity in natural language (see Coppock (2018) for a technical formulation). I use the term “outlook marker” in a more restricted sense, to refer to items sensitive to the structure of the discourse listed in (1) and (2) and excluding more general evaluative items such as those in (7) whose

meanings just depend on contextual parameters pertaining to the speaker's attitude.

It is important to note that regardless of the status of these evaluative meanings, they are not just pragmatic inferences derived via Gricean principles but are tied to the conventional meanings of these words. This is shown by the fact that this meaning component is not cancelable. Note the following examples, where the additional expressions (preceding clauses or adverbial modifiers) whose entailments contradict the evaluative meanings of outlook markers robustly give rise to infelicity.

- (10) #*Satō-iri-no* *ryokucha-wa* *jitsu-ni* *mooshi-bun-nai* *mono-da-ga*,
sugar-put.in-GEN green.tea-TOP real-ADV complaint-NEG thing-COP-but
watashi-wa *satō-iri-no* *ryokucha* ***nanka*** *kesshite* *nomanai*.
I-TOP sugar-put.in-GEN green.tea NANKA never drink-NEG
‘Green tea with sugar is indeed impeccable, but I never drink such a thing.’
- (11) *Igai-na* *koto-ni*, *sunao-ni* *misu-o* *mitome-ta* *hō-ga*
unexpected-ADN thing-DAT honest-ADV mistake-ACC admit-PAST way-NOM
{***mushiro/yahari***} *yoi* *kekka-ni* *tsunagaru*.
rather/as.expected good result-DAT lead.to
‘Unexpectedly, honestly admitting one’s mistake leads (rather/#as expected) to a better outcome.’
- (12) *Igai-na* *koto-wa* *nani-mo* *na-ku*, *sunao-ni* *misu-o*
unexpected thing-TOP nothing exist-NEG honestly mistake-ACC
mitome-ta *hō-ga* {***#mushiro/yahari***} *yoi* *kekka-ni* *tsunagaru*.
admit-PAST way-NOM rather/after.all good result-DAT lead
‘Nothing surprising; frankly admitting your mistake leads (#rather/as expected) to better results.’

In fact, it has long been recognized in the descriptive tradition in Japanese linguistics that certain adverbs and focus particles encode the speaker's subjective attitude (Kudo 1977; Numata 1986; Morimoto 1988, among others).¹ These items largely correspond to a subclass of adverbial expressions that Yamada (1936) identified as “predicative adverbs” (*chinjutsu fukushi* in Japanese), that is, adverbial expressions tied to the concept of *chinjutsu* (“predication”) that is one of the central components of Yamada’s conception of Japanese grammar. More recent literature tends to focus on the specific ways in which these adverbs and particles impose co-

¹ Discourse particles in certain languages often have similar profiles (Zimmermann 2019). The so-called “modal particles” in German (Egg 2013; Repp 2013; Gutzmann 2017; Abraham 2021) are especially interesting in this connection. They often have obscure and hard-to-delineate pragmatic functions similar to certain focus particles in Japanese, and there is a rich tradition of descriptive studies on this class of words.

occurrence restrictions on the forms of sentence-final modal, aspectual, and speech-act expressions (Morimoto 1988, 1994; Numata 1989; Noda 1995; Kudo 2016, among others).

However, detailed semantic analyses of these expressions are surprisingly scarce, especially within contemporary theoretical work on semantics and pragmatics. Although there have been some isolated attempts (for example, Hara (2006) and Tomioka (2010) on contrastive *wa* and Sawada (2018) on certain degree adverbs), the main focus of these studies tends to be ways in which such items relate to theoretical issues (such as information structure (“given”/“new” information), multi-dimensional meaning (compositionality), and scalarity/polarity (differences in entailment properties)) that do not necessarily correspond to the central properties of outlook markers. Against this background, a recent proposal by Kubota and Ido (2026a,b) attempts to make sense of outlook markers within a theory of discourse that takes negotiations of stance-dependent update proposals to be a central component of natural language discourse. The model they develop combines Coppock’s (2018) outlook-based semantics for the treatment of subjectivity and Farkas and Bruce’s (2010) Table model for discourse management. Similar ideas have occasionally been entertained in studies of semantics and pragmatics outside of Japanese linguistics. For example, Zeevat (2004) and Egg (2013) have advocated views that take meta-level relations between the utterance and the prior discourse to be central. These proposals can be seen as precursors of Kubota and Ido’s approach I outline in Section 3.

The main goal of this chapter is to examine outlook markers in their own right and consider ways in which they may shed new light on attempts at developing a formal theory of natural language discourse. Since achieving this goal requires an accurate understanding of the literature, the rest of this paper contains a relatively long literature review (Section 2). I start with a tentative classification of secondary meanings into three broad classes. This will be followed by a review of previous research on presuppositions and CIs (Sections 2.1–2.3), focusing especially on aspects relevant to the treatment of outlook markers. Based on this background, Section 3 examines the properties of outlook markers in detail and discusses their theoretical implications.

2 (Known) varieties of secondary meaning

What exactly are the meanings and functions of words like *nanka* and *mushiro* in examples such as (13)?

- (13) a. *Watashi-ni-wa kinmedaru **nanka** tor-e-nai.*
 I-DAT-TOP gold.medal NANKA take-POT-NEG
 ‘I can’t win (anything like) a gold medal.’
- b. *Sunao-ni misu-o mitome-ta hō-ga **mushiro** yoi.*
 honestly mistake-ACC admit-PAST way-NOM rather good
 ‘Frankly admitting your mistake is (actually) better.’

Intuitively, outlook markers do not seem to add any substantial meaning. For example, unlike other focus particles such as *dake* ‘only’ and *mo* ‘also,’ omitting *nanka* **does not** drastically

change the meaning of the prejacent in (13a).² Descriptively, the main function of these words is instead to add some subjective implication to the propositional content of the sentence. Such secondary meanings are called “non-at-issue” or “projective” meaning in the recent literature (see, e.g., Tonhauser et al. 2013; Potts 2015; Sawada 2018). The typology of secondary meanings has become a central topic since the reinvention of the concept of “Conventional Implicature” (CI) by Potts (2003, 2005). Thus, clarifying the status of outlook markers is directly relevant to current theoretical research in semantics and pragmatics for the purpose of advancing our understanding of the inventory of meanings that natural language expressions can encode.³

The prevailing view in the literature is that non-asserted meanings of sentences can be divided into three broad categories: conversational implicature, presupposition, and CI. Teasing apart conversational implicature from the other two is relatively unproblematic, via the standard cancelability test. The much more controversial issue is where to draw the line (if at all) between presupposition and CI. The broad consensus seems to be that the two classes are conceptually distinct—presuppositions are “preconditions” for discourse update, whereas CIs are non-essential implications that arise (for example, due to the particular choice of words) when discourse update takes place. Nevertheless, there is currently no established set of empirical diagnostics to distinguish CIs from presuppositions, and discussions on this issue are often unclear and inconclusive in the analyses of specific phenomena. Outlook markers are interesting in this context since they display both presuppositional and CI-like properties.

This raises the question of whether there is a third category, or if one item can possess two meaning components simultaneously. Yet another possibility is that the whole classification needs to be rethought. As Potts (2015) suggests, what is really needed now may be a radical overhaul of the familiar (and supposedly well-understood) notions and analytic toolkits. This requires decomposing the concepts of presupposition and CI into more basic notions of discourse management such as the status of pending issues in discourse, what stances interlocutors have toward such pending issues, and what strategies they take in negotiating about joint common ground update. This may push the boundaries of current work and lead to a new theory of discourse management in natural language. The discussion in the remainder of this chapter aims to identify promising directions for future research along these lines.

For the purpose of the ensuing discussion, I propose the classification of secondary meanings in (14). This is aimed at classifying as many phenomena as possible, especially, with the aim of identifying the proper place of outlook markers within a broad typology of secondary

² Following the common terminology, for a structure $\phi(p)$ in which some sentential operator ϕ takes a sentence p as its argument, I call p the “prejacent”; intuitively the prejacent is just the sentence from which the operator is removed. For example, if we take *only* to be a sentential operator, rather than a nominal operator, the proposition *John came* is the prejacent of *Only John came*.

³ The term “conventional implicature” originates with Grice (1967), who used it to describe the adversative meaning of the connective *but*.

meanings that has relatively clear conceptual underpinnings. For this reason, the three-way classification I present in (14) does not correspond to the familiar distinction between presuppositions and CIs, at least not in any straightforward way. It should also be noted that the literature on presupposition (and projective meanings more generally) is vast and complex; thus, providing a comprehensive overview is neither intended nor possible. To compensate for this, I recommend the readers to consult other sources as well, such as Levinson (1983) and Beaver et al. (2024).

(14) Subclasses of “secondary meaning” (cf. Levinson 1983; Tonhauser et al. 2013; Potts 2015; Beaver et al. 2024)

a. **Anaphoric presupposition triggers**

- pronouns, anaphora
- definites, demonstratives
- clefts
- additives (*too, also*)

b. **Conditions on lexicalized concepts**

- aspectual predicates (*continue, stop*)
- temporal connectives (*before, after*)
- factive predicates (*know, regret, discover*)
- implicative predicates (*manage, succeed, fail*)
- manner adverbs (*quickly, carefully*)
- sortal restrictions (semantic restrictions on content words)
- expressives (honorifics, slurs)

c. **Discourse-sensitive modifiers and connectives**

- scalar adverbs (*almost, barely, at least*)
- discourse/focus particles (*doch, ja, even, contrastive wa*)
- discourse-sensitive adverbs (*of course, mushiro, yoppodo*)
- discourse connectives (*but, therefore*)
- evidentials
- appositives, non-restrictive modifiers

Anaphoric presupposition triggers in (14a) include items that have been treated as prototypical cases of presupposition triggers in the tradition of dynamic semantics (Heim 1982; Kamp 1981; van der Sandt 1992). Additives and clefts are “anaphoric” in the sense that the “antecedents” of the relevant presuppositional meanings can be identified in the discourse in a way parallel to anaphora resolution of pronouns. For example, *John came to the party too* is felicitous only if the previous discourse has mentioned somebody other than John who came to the party. Some of the items classified under conditions on lexicalized concepts in (14b) (such as aspectual predicates and factives) are textbook examples of presupposition. But detailed analyses of these items in the formal semantics literature are surprisingly scarce (but see Roberts and Simons (2024) for a recent study on English *stop*, and Degen and Tonhauser (2022), which reports the results of a

careful experimental study on the alleged class of “factive” predicates in English). Some of the items in this class are known as “soft triggers” (Abusch 2002; Abrusán 2011), as they do not invoke the presuppositions that are (taken to be) associated with them as robustly as “hard triggers” such as the anaphoric presupposition triggers in (14a) (see Section 3.3 below). Honorifics and slurs are often treated under the notion of *expressive* meaning, and are standardly taken to be a variety of CIs (see McCready (2021) for a recent overview on expressives). The last class, discourse-sensitive modifiers and connectives (14c), includes the class of outlook markers. This last class is perhaps the most problematic among the three. Descriptively, many items in this class exhibit properties that are similar to presuppositions in some respects and to CIs in other respects. Theoretically, the way they differ from the more prototypical presupposition triggers (anaphoric and lexical) is not well understood.

2.1 Conventional Implicature

Potts (2003, 2005) aimed to re-cast the notion of Conventional Implicature (CI) within the contemporary compositional theory of natural language meaning. As paradigmatic cases of CI, Potts initially identified appositives in (15) and expressives such as Japanese honorifics in (16) (or slurs like *the bastard*).

(15) Lance, a cyclist, won the Tour de France.

↗ Lance is a cyclist.

(16) *Tanaka-kyōju-ga hon-o o-kaki-ni-natta.*

Prof.Tanaka-NOM book-ACC write.HON

‘Professor Tanaka has written a book.’

↗ The speaker respects Professor Tanaka.’

Unlike conversational implicatures, CI meanings are uncancellable. Moreover, it is independent of the propositional content of the sentence. This can be confirmed by the following type of data.

(17) Lance, a cyclist, won the Tour de France. #He is in fact not a cyclist.

(18) a. Lance, a cyclist, won the Tour de France.

b. #That’s not true. He’s not a cyclist.

(cf. That’s not true. He didn’t win the Tour de France.)

From the data in (17) and (18), we can see that the meaning of appositives constitutes a type of secondary meaning (the same point can be established for honorifics using analogous tests; examples are omitted here).

Having confirmed that CIs expressed by appositives and honorifics constitute secondary meanings, the next question is what type of secondary meanings they are. The discussion in Potts

(2003, 2005) is somewhat unclear about the question of whether one can establish CIs as a distinct class apart from presuppositions. However, the compositional mechanism he develops for CIs is clearly different from—and much simpler than—the standard approach to presupposition projection available in the contemporary literature (which are extensions of the Heim/Kamp dynamic semantics model). Potts’s model of CIs has two distinct yet closely related features: speaker-orientation and independence from truth assessment. The latter is exemplified by the denial test in (18) and the projection test we introduce below. Speaker-orientation refers to the property allegedly common to both appositives and expressives where the knowledge or attitude expressed by the secondary meaning is attributed to the speaker of the sentence (thus, in *John told me that Lance, a cyclist, won the Tour de France*, it is the speaker and not John who believes that Lance is a cyclist). It is important to keep in mind that presuppositions don’t necessarily robustly exhibit speaker-orientation in this sense (see below in Section 3.2). For example, in *After learning from Mary that Sue would come to the party, John thought that Peter would come **too***, the additive presupposition of *too* is satisfied locally; for this sentence to be felicitous, it only needs to be the case that John (but not the speaker) believes that somebody other than Peter will come to the party.

Of these two properties, speaker-orientation is perhaps a clearer identifier of CIs against presuppositions—or at least it seemed so initially. However, later work has shown that, with certain conditions, appositive content (and certain other CIs) can be non-speaker-oriented, i.e., attributed to the attitude holder (Wang et al. 2005; Amaral et al. 2007; Harris & Potts 2009):

- (19) [Joan is crazy. She’s hallucinating that some geniuses in Silicon Valley have invented a new brain chip that’s been installed in her left temporal lobe and permits her to speak any of a number of languages she’s never studied.]
Joan believes that her chip, which she had installed last month, has a twelve-year guarantee.
(adapted from Amaral et al. 2007: 736)

This leaves us only independence from truth assessment as a candidate for a presupposition-CI distinction, but this diagnostic is actually even more problematic. To see this, note that a simple denial test like that in (18) **does not** really reliably distinguish CIs from presuppositions. Though conceptually different in status, presuppositions are similar in behavior to CIs in that they cannot be the target of direct denial. The other test for independence from truth assessment is the projection test with the so-called “family of sentences.” That is, CIs project over truth-functional operators such as negation, modals, antecedents of conditionals, and questions. Examples with conditionals are given in (20):

- (20) a. If Lance, a cyclist, wins the Tour de France, then everyone will be surprised.
b. *Tanaka-kyōju-ga hon-o o-kaki-ni-nattara, mina-de*
Prof.Tanaka-NOM book-ACC HON-write-HON-if everyone-with

oiwai-o suru yotei da.
 celebration-ACC do plan COP
 ‘If Professor Tanaka writes a book, we plan to celebrate together.’

In (20a), the appositive is embedded inside the antecedent of a conditional clause—an environment that introduces a hypothetical situation. But it still follows from the whole sentence that Lance is a cyclist (by contrast, the at-issue content that he wins the Tour de France **does not** project to the whole sentence). Similarly, if the speaker sincerely utters (20b), then their respect for Tanaka is still unambiguously conveyed to the hearer. The problem here in using this diagnostic is that this family of sentences test is precisely the classical test for presupposition (see, e.g., Chierchia and McConnell-Ginet (1990) for a textbook exposition). We show in the next section that at least unequivocal cases of presupposition robustly project in the same set of environments.

To summarize the discussion up to this point, CIs invoked by appositives and expressives are unquestionably noncancelable secondary meanings, but it remains unclear whether CIs form a distinct subclass of secondary meaning, and if so, what exactly the criteria are for distinguishing CIs from presuppositions.

2.2 Presupposition

Presupposition has a much longer research history than (the modern incarnation of) CIs, dating back to theoretical debates in generative linguistics in the 1970s. One of the most important properties of presuppositions is *projection* (Karttunen 1973). That is, presuppositions are known to project when embedded under the “family of sentences” environments, as noted at the end of the previous section. Levinson (1983) is useful for the purpose of getting a sense of the complexity and depth of the empirical phenomena and the theoretical issues that were already known in early research on presupposition. With hindsight, it is suggestive that the chapter on presupposition in Levinson (1983) ends with a comparison of Karttunen and Peters (1979) and Gazdar (1979), the two major approaches to presupposition projection at that time which contrast sharply in their orientation: Karttunen and Peters (1979) work out a complex and detailed compositional theory in the framework of Montague Grammar, whereas Gazdar’s (1979) approach is fundamentally pragmatic. Later research history of secondary meanings can be seen as variations on the same theme: what exactly is the right division of labor between “grammar” and “pragmatics” in the analyses of these phenomena?

Among the three classes in (14), anaphoric presupposition triggers exhibit the prototypical properties associated with presuppositions most robustly. I use the additive adverb *mata* ‘again’ and the demonstrative *sono* ‘that’ as examples here.

- (21) a. *Jon-wa kono aida mata korona-ni nat-ta.*
 John-TOP the.other.day again COVID- DAT become- PAST
 ‘John got COVID again the other day.’
 ↗ John had COVID before.’

- b. *Tarō-wa sono hon-o mot-te-i-ru-yo.*
 Taro-TOP that book-ACC have-PROG-SFP
 ‘Taro has that book.’

↗ There is some salient book in the discourse; the speaker and the hearer both know which one they are talking about.’

The presuppositions triggered by these expressions project when embedded under questions and modals. That is, in a structure $\phi(p)$ where a question operator or a modal operator ϕ takes some proposition p as an argument, the presupposition of p becomes the presupposition of the whole sentence $\phi(p)$. This can be tested by the following examples in which the follow-up sentences explicitly contradicts with the relevant presuppositions, thereby giving rise to robust infelicity:

- (22) a. *Jon-wa kono aida mata korona-ni nat-ta-no? #Tashika*
 John-TOP the.other.day again COVID-DAT become-PAST-Q surely
kare korona ni naru-no-wa hajimete datta-yo-ne.
 he COVID DAT become-NMZ-TOP first.time COP-SFP-SFP
 ‘Did John get COVID again the other day? As I recall, this was probably his first time getting COVID.’
- b. *Jon-wa kono aida mata korona-ni nat-ta-rashii. #Mottomo,*
 John-TOP the.other.day again COVID-DAT become-seem however
kono aida-ga hajimete datta kanōsei-mo aru-ga.
 the.other.day-NOM first.time COP possibility-also exist-but
 ‘It seems John got COVID again the other day. Though that may actually have been the first time he got COVID.’
- (23) a. *Tarō-wa sono hon-o mot-te-ru ka-na? #Sore-tomo, betsu-ni*
 Taro-TOP that book-ACC have-PROG Q-SFP or else anyway
hon-no hanashi nanka shi-te-i-na-kat-ta-kke?
 book-GEN talk NANKA do-PROG-NEG-PAST-Q
 ‘I wonder if Taro has that book. Or else, was it the case that we weren’t even talking about any book in the first place?’
- b. *Tarō nara sono hon-o mot-te-ru kamo. #Sore-tomo, betsu-ni*
 Taro if that book-ACC have-PROG-maybe or else anyway
hon-no hanashi nanka shi-te-i-na-kat-ta-kke?
 book-GEN talk NANKA do-PROG-NEG-PAST-Q
 ‘Taro might have that book. Or else, **was it the case** that we weren’t even talking about any book in the first place?’

Also, like CIs, presuppositions cannot be the target of truth-evaluation by expressions like *Is*

that true?, which target the main proposition rather than secondary content.

- (24) A: *Jon-wa kono aida mata korona-ni nat-ta.*
 John-TOP the.other.day again COVID-DAT become-PAST
 ‘John got COVID again the other day’
 B: # *Soo-ka-na? Jon-ga korona-ni nat-ta-no-wa*
 so-Q-SFP John-NOM COVID-DAT become-PAST-NMZ-TOP
hajimete-dewa?
 first.time-Q
 intended: ‘Is that right? Isn’t this John’s first time getting COVID?’
- (25) A: *Tarō-wa sono hon-o mot-te-i-ru-yo.*
 Taro-TOP that book-ACC have-PROG-SFP
 ‘Taro has that book.’
 B: # *Soo-ka-na? Kimi-ga dono hon-no koto-o*
 so-Q-SFP you-NOM which book-GEN thing-ACC
itte-iru-no-ka boku-ni-wa wakara-nai-kedo.
 say-PROG-NML I-DAT-TOP understand -NEG-but
 intended: ‘Is that right? I don’t really know which book you’re talking about.’

Presuppositions generally allow for readings in which they are attributed to the belief holder when embedded under attitude predicates (see Heim (1992), among others). For instance, in the following example, it is sufficient that the presupposition “John had COVID before” holds within Hanako’s belief; this presupposition does not have to be part of the common ground (i.e., shared knowledge between the speaker and the hearer).

- (26) *Hanako-wa Jon-ga kono aida mata korona-ni nat-ta-to*
 Hanako-TOP John-NOM the other.day again COVID-DAT become-PAST-COMP
omot-te-iru.
 think-PROG
 ‘Hanako thinks that John got COVID again the other day.’

As we have seen in Section 2.1, CIs tend to exhibit speaker-orientation, but **that is** not an absolute rule, and empirical facts are somewhat complex and still not well understood. (26) shows that presuppositions can generally allow for anchoring to local attitude holders.

A perennial issue in the literature on CIs and presuppositions is the lack of a clear diagnostic to tell them apart. The above discussion should make it clear that major tests for presuppositions and CIs, namely, deniability, projectivity, and speaker-orientation, can only separate secondary (or non-at-issue) meanings from at-issue meanings but are useless for distinguishing between the two subclasses of the secondary meanings. Instead of trying to identify an operational test, Potts (2007) proposes to characterize expressives, which constitute a major subclass of CIs, in terms of properties they satisfy listed in (27).

(27) Properties of expressives (Potts 2007)

- a. **Independence:** Expressive content contributes a dimension of meaning that is separate from the regular descriptive content.
- b. **Nondisplaceability:** Expressives predicate something of the utterance situation.
- c. **Perspective Dependence:** Expressive content is evaluated from a particular perspective. In general, the perspective is the speaker's, but there can be deviations if conditions are right.
- d. **Descriptive Ineffability:** Speakers are never fully satisfied when they paraphrase expressive content using descriptive, i.e., nonexpressive, terms.
- e. **Immediacy:** Like performatives, expressives achieve their intended act simply by being uttered; they do not offer content so much as inflict it.
- f. **Repeatability:** If a speaker repeatedly uses an expressive item, the effect is generally one of strengthening the emotive content, rather than one of redundancy.

Of these properties, “descriptive ineffability” and “immediacy” seem particularly important as they distinguish expressives from prototypical presupposition triggers. “Descriptive ineffability” refers to the fact that the effects that CI triggers induce cannot be paraphrased by language. For example, the use of honorifics signals to the hearer that the speaker is abiding by some social norms according to which showing reverence to some person is taken to be appropriate in the particular situation in which the utterance takes place. This is different from saying in words that one respects the person in question. “Immediacy” is a closely related concept. The effects of expressives arise as a result of the use of the particular words that have the effects in question. Honorifics and derogatory terms are among the many possible ways to describe the same situation; expressive meanings are conveyed via the choice of words which is orthogonal to the facts of the matter that the propositional content of the sentence conveys. While this still leaves open the issue of whether there are nonexpressive CIs, and, if so, how they are distinguished from presuppositions, identifying the use-related, perspective-sensitive properties of expressives is useful for the purpose of clarifying the nature of different types of secondary meanings. We return to this point in Section 3, where we discuss the properties of outlook markers which exhibit a somewhat different type of perspective-sensitivity than expressives.

2.3 Soft vs. hard triggers

Besides anaphoric presupposition triggers in (14a), well-known presupposition triggers include expressions in (14b), where the presupposition pertains to conditions on lexicalized concepts such as the meanings of aspectual predicates (*continue*, *stop*) and certain implicative verbs (*manage*, *succeed*, *fail*). The secondary meanings of this class of expressions are known as “soft triggers,” as they behave less stably than anaphoric triggers (which are “hard triggers”) with respect to the projection test and the status as common ground knowledge. In this subsection, I examine the properties of these soft triggers, taking the aspectual verb *yameru* ‘stop’ and the implicative verb *seikō-suru* ‘succeed’ in Japanese as examples.

The verbs *yameru* ‘stop’ and *seikō-suru* ‘succeed’ are standardly taken to have the following presuppositions:

- (28) *Jon-wa saikin tabako-o yame-ta mitai-da.*
 John-TOP recently tobacco-ACC stop-PAST seem-COP
 ‘It seems John recently quit smoking.’
 ↗ John used to smoke.

- (29) *Tanaka-wa saikin shochō-o settoku-suru koto-ni seikō-shi-ta mitai-da.*
 Tanaka-TOP recently director-ACC persuade-do NML-DAT succeed-PAST seem-COP
 ‘It seems Tanaka recently succeeded in persuading the director.’
 ↗ Tanaka had been trying to persuade the director.

The intuition here is that for it to make sense to say that someone ‘stopped’ doing something, the person in question must have been engaged in the activity in the first place. Similarly, for somebody to have ‘succeeded’ in something, it has to be that they had made an attempt. In this sense, these presuppositions can be seen as lexical preconditions, inherent to the concepts denoted by the predicates (see Roberts and Simons 2024 for an analysis that articulates this analytic intuition thoroughly).

These secondary meanings typically project under modals, questions, and antecedents of conditionals. The example in (30) all presuppose that John used to smoke. Similarly, the examples in (31) all presuppose that Tanaka tried to persuade the director.

- (30) a. *Jon-wa tabako-o yameru-ka-na?*
 John-TOP tobacco-ACC quit-Q-SFP
 ‘I wonder if John will quit smoking.’
 b. *Jon-wa tabako-o yameru-beki-da.*
 John-TOP tobacco-ACC quit-should-COP
 ‘John should quit smoking.’
 c. *Jon-ga tabako-o yameru-nara, chotto tsukiatte-mi-tai.*
 John-NOM tobacco-ACC quit-COND a.bit date -try-want
 ‘If John quits smoking, I’d perhaps want to date him.’
- (31) a. *Tanaka-san-wa shochō-o settoku-suru-no-ni seikō-suru-ka-na?*
 Mr. Tanaka-TOP director-ACC persuade-do-NML-DAT succeed-do-Q-SFP
 ‘I wonder if Tanaka will succeed in persuading the director.’
 b. *Tanaka-san-wa shochō-o settoku-suru-no-ni seikō-suru kamo.*
 Mr. Tanaka-TOP director-ACC persuade-do-DAT succeed-do may

‘Tanaka might succeed in persuading the director.’

- c. *Tanaka-san-ga shochō-o settoku-suru-no-ni seikō-sure-ba,*
 Mr.Tanaka-NOM director-ACC persuade-do-DAT succeed-if
kazamidori-no Yamada-san-wa Tanaka-san-to kumu darō.
 weathercock-GEN Mr.Yamada-TOP Tanaka-with team.up will
 ‘If Tanaka succeeds in persuading the director, the weathervane Yamada will team up with Tanaka.’

The lexical preconditions of words like *yameru* and *seikō-suru* do not exhibit the properties of expressives. For example, descriptive ineffability does not hold since *John stopped smoking* can be accurately paraphrased as “John used to smoke and he does not do so any longer”; the latter paraphrase is only redundant in explicitly stating what is presupposed in the former. Similarly, this type of precondition lacks nondisplaceability. This can be shown most clearly in examples involving embedding. In *John believes that Mary stopped smoking*, the precondition pertains to John’s belief, having nothing to do with the utterance situation.

From these, it appears reasonable to treat the preconditions of *yameru* ‘stop’ and *seikō-suru* ‘succeed’ as presuppositions. At the same time, however, it is well known that these presuppositions do not always project robustly in embedded environments (see, e.g., Abusch 2002; Abrusán 2011; Roberts & Simons 2024). Below are some examples involving questions and antecedents of conditionals which seems to allow for readings in which projection is blocked relatively easily.

- (32) a. *Jon-tte tabako yame-ta-no? Aruiwa, kare non-sumōkā dat-ta-kke?*
 John-TOP tobacco quit-Q or he non-smoker COP-PAST-Q
 ‘Did John quit smoking? Or perhaps was he a non-smoker?’
- b. *Tanaka-san-wa, tabako-o yame-re-ba taichō-ga yoku-naru darō.*
 Mr. Tanaka-TOP tobacco-ACC stop-if condition-NOM good-be will
Tabako-wa suwa-nai-no-nara, osake-o yame-re-ba yoi.
 tobacco-TOP not.smoke-if alcohol-ACC stop-if good
 ‘If Tanaka quits smoking, his health will improve. If he does not smoke, then he should quit drinking.’
- (33) a. *Dō, shochō-o settoku-suru koto-ni seikō-shi-ta? Aruiwa,*
 how director-ACC persuade-do NML-DAT succeed-do-PAST or
shochō-to-wa mada hanashi-te nai?
 director-with-TOP yet talk-PROG NEG
 ‘So, did you succeed in persuading the director? Or have you not talked to the director yet?’

- b. *Shochō-o settoku-suru-no-ni seikō-sure-ba, purojekuto-wa mitomerareru*
 director-ACC persuade-do-DAT succeed-if project-TOP be.approved
darō. Mā, shochō-to jikadanpan-suru-no-o kirau nara, kaigi-de
 probable well director-with direct.talk-ACC dislike if meeting-at
nebarizuyoku kōshō-suru-no-ga seikōhō dakedo.
 persistently negotiate-do-NMZ-NOM right.way though
 ‘If you succeed in persuading the director, the project will probably be approved. Well,
 if you dislike direct talks with the director, persistent negotiation in meetings is the
 proper route.’

(32a) seems to receive a coherent interpretation as an utterance by a speaker who believes that John was a smoker but is not totally certain about their belief. On this reading, the presupposition “John used to smoke” **does not** project from under the question operator; if it did, that would directly contradict the follow-up explicitly denying that implication. Similarly, the antecedent of a conditional is normally a projective environment, but again, in (32b), the follow-up sentence would be directly contradictory with the presupposition triggered by *yameru* ‘stop.’ Here again, epistemic uncertainty on the part of the speaker seems to be the key that blocks the usual projective behavior. (33a,b) are similar examples with the implicative verb *seikō-suru* ‘succeed’.

What licenses the non-projective readings of soft triggers in (32) and (33) is unclear. Note that, by contrast, the hard trigger *mata* ‘again’ **tends to project more robustly**. The following examples, which are the hard-trigger counterparts of the non-projection examples in (32) and (33), do not seem to allow for coherent interpretations as readily as the soft-trigger variants.⁴

- (34) a.?? *Jon-tte mata korona-ni nat-ta-no? Aruiwa,*
 John-TOP again COVID-DAT become-Q or
konkai-ga hajimete dat-ta-kke?
 this.time-NOM first.time COP-PAST-Q
 ‘Did John get COVID again? Or was this the first time?’

- b.?? *Tanaka-san-ga mata korona-ni nat-tara, kono aida yasu-nda*
 Mr. Tanaka-NOM again COVID-DAT become-if recently rest-PAST
Itō-san-ni kawari-o tanomō. Hajimete nara, beteran-no
 Mr.Itō-DAT substitute-ACC ask first.time if old.hand-GEN
Yamamoto-san-ni tanomō.
 Mr.Yamamoto-DAT ask

‘If Tanaka gets COVID again, let’s ask Mr. Ito – who was off the other day – to cover.

⁴The contrast between hard and soft triggers here is arguably a matter of degree, not a reflection of a hard-and-fast constraint. Though I believe that the tendency itself is real, some speakers may find the judgments on these examples not entirely clear-cut. Disentangling the various factors that influence the acceptability of these examples is an issue that I have to leave for future study.

If it's the first time he gets COVID, let's ask the old hand Ms. Yamamoto.'

What exactly is the difference between lexical preconditions in (14b) (aspectual predicates (e.g., *continue*, *stop*), temporal connectives (e.g., *before*, *after*), etc.) and anaphoric triggers in (14a) (pronouns, definites, clefts and additives)? One possible difference is that the former class encodes some sort of overridable “default assumption” while the presupposition of the latter doesn't have that property. That is, when the speaker says that somebody “stopped” smoking, then the assumption is that the person in question used to smoke. Normally this assumption is common ground between the speaker and the hearer, but the non-projecting examples are cases in which there are reasons to believe that the precondition is merely a presumption on the part of the speaker. By contrast, anaphoric presuppositions are by definition anaphoric to the previous discourse context shared among interlocutors. That is, they are tightly anchored to some given information in the current discourse. Presumably, such anaphoric relations cannot be overridden so easily, similar to the way antecedent-less pronouns are simply uninterpretable. This is, of course, only a very preliminary speculation, and a more thorough investigation is needed on this issue. The question of why soft triggers and hard triggers differ in the way they do is currently an open issue in the literature. Some of the representative proposals include an account based on focus alternatives (Abusch 2002, 2010), an account that invokes the notion of “aboutness” (Abrusán 2011), and an account that combines the concept of preconditions with the speaker's discourse-strategic choices (Roberts & Simons 2024).

3 The status of secondary meanings of outlook markers

It should be clear at this point that the influential classification of secondary meanings into CIs and presuppositions leaves many issues open; most importantly, it is unclear where exactly the boundary is between these two categories, and whether we have a reliable set of diagnostics to tease them apart empirically. Yet at the same time, it seems reasonable (and useful) to classify secondary meanings into a couple of broad representative classes that differ in nature substantially: (i) expressives, (ii) anaphoric presuppositions, and (iii) lexical preconditions, or “soft triggers.” These classes appear to reflect different discourse status that different types of secondary meanings embody.

Given this state of affairs, how should we make sense of the secondary meanings of outlook markers, repeated here as in (35) and (36)?

(35) Adverbs

- a. *dōse* ‘anyway’, *shosen* ‘anyway’, *yahari* ‘after all’, *kekkyoku* ‘after all’ [Morimoto 1994; Takeuchi 2015]
- b. *masani* ‘precisely’, *mushiro* ‘rather’, *mashite* ‘let alone’, *semete* ‘at least’ [Kudo 1977]
- c. *yoppodo* ‘rather’, *kaette* ‘rather’ [Sawada 2010]

(36) **Focus particles**

nanka ‘anything like’, *kurai* ‘at least’, *koso* ‘precisely’ [Numata 1986; Sawada 2007; Ido 2023]

As a point of departure for exploring this issue, **let us** get back to a simple but important observation that has from time to time been made in the descriptive literature, independently for different items listed under (2): words like *nanka* and *kurai* are felicitous only when certain issues that relate in particular ways to the prejacent is salient in the discourse (Abe 1999; Sawada 2007; Ido 2023). For example, in (37), B’s utterance containing *nanka* is natural as a negative response to A’s remark, which expresses a positive evaluation of sweetened green tea.

- (37) A: *Satō-iri-no ryokucha-tte, oishii yo ne.*
sugar-containing-GEN green.tea-TOP tasty SFP SFP
‘Sweetened green tea is tasty, isn’t it?’
- B: *Ge, amai mono-wa suki-da kedo, satō-iri-no ryokucha nanka*
ugh sweet things-TOP like-COP but sugar-containing-GEN green.tea NANKA
zettai oishiku nai yo.
absolutely tasty NEG SFP
‘Ugh, I do like sweets, but sweetened green tea is absolutely not tasty.’

When no such counterstance is present, *nanka* is unacceptable. For example, by slightly modifying the exchange in (37) by replacing A’s original utterance with a general *wh*-question as in (38), B’s response becomes infelicitous.

- (38) A: *Donna nomimono-ni satō-o ireru-no-ga oishii-ka-na?*
what.kind drink-DAT sugar-ACC put-GEN-NOM delicious-Q-SFP
‘I wonder what kind of drink tastes good with sugar in it.’
- B: *Satō-iri-no ryokucha- {wa/??nanka} oishiku-nai-yo.*
sugar-with-GEN green.tea-TOP/NANKA delicious-NEG-SFP
‘Sweetened green tea is not tasty (at all).’

In (38), whether or not sweetened green tea is delicious is not at issue immediately prior to B’s utterance. Such a context does not support the use of *nanka*, as there is no salient counterstance.

Many of the adverbs in (1) seem to impose the same type of condition on the preceding context. Note, for example, that a response with *dōse* is felicitous for the question Q1 but not for Q2 in the following Q-A pair.

- (39) Q1: *Satō-iri-no ryokucha-wa oishii-ka-na?*
sugar-containing-GEN green.tea-TOP delicious-Q-SFP
‘I wonder if sweetened green tea is tasty.’
- Q2: *Donna nomimono-ni satō-o ireru-no-ga oishii-ka-na?*

what.kind drink-DAT sugar-ACC put-GEN-NOM delicious-Q-SFP
'I wonder what kind of drink tastes good with sugar in it.'

- A: *Satō-iri-no ryokucha-wa dōse mazui yo.*
sugar-containing-GEN green.tea DŌSE untasty SFP
'Sweetened green tea is untasty anyway.'
OK as a response to Q1
as a response to Q2

These data suggest that *dōse* is similar to *nanka* in that it requires the discourse to contain a salient issue which the prejacent directly responds to.

Outlook markers express some kind of evaluation of “plausibility,” “desirability,” or “likelihood” on top of this condition imposed on the prior discourse (see, e.g., Sawada 2007). For instance, in (37), B’s use of *nanka* explicitly conveys a negative stance toward sweetened green tea. This expression of negative stance is similar in some sense to the type of meanings expressed by expressives. One characteristic it shares with typical expressives is that this meaning component cannot be the target of a yes/no response by the hearer. As shown in (40) and (41), when B responds to a sentence uttered by A containing words such as *nanka* and *dōse* with a simple “no” response, what is denied is the propositional content of A’s utterance rather than whatever additional negative meaning is evoked by the use of *nanka* or *dōse*.

- (40) A: *Satō-iri-no ryokucha nanka watashi-wa noma-nai.*
sugar-put-GEN green.tea NANKA I-TOP drink-NEG
'I won't drink green tea with sugar or anything like that.'
B: *Iya, sonna hazu-wa nai yo.*
No such case-TOP NEG SFP
'No, that can't be true.'
(≈ 'You'll drink it for sure.')(≈ 'You are not negative about green tea with sugar.')

- (41) A: *Watashi-ni-wa dōse kinmedaru-wa tor-e-nai.*
I-DAT-TOP anyway gold.medal-TOP take-POT-NEG
'I can't win a gold medal anyway.'
B: *Iya, sonna hazu-wa nai yo.*
No such case-TOP NEG SFP
'No, that can't be true.'
(≈ 'You have plenty of chances.')(≈ 'You aren't really so pessimistic.')

Indeed, the negative evaluation meanings of outlook markers share with expressives at least two of their key properties: “descriptive ineffability” and “immediacy” in (27). These meanings

are essentially manifestations of attitudes or stances that result from the use of particular words, and by their very nature cannot be paraphrased by propositions that are either true or false.

To summarize the discussion up to this point, descriptively outlook markers can be understood as involving “two-layered” secondary meanings: a presuppositional component that requires the existence of some salient issue in the prior discourse, and an expressive-like component that embodies the speaker’s stance in situating the utterance content with respect to the salient issue. To better understand the nature of outlook markers and to see how exactly the latter meaning component often leads to evaluative implications, we need to examine its nature more closely, especially ways in which outlook markers differ from typical expressives.

One notable difference between typical expressives like honorifics and slurs and outlook markers is that the latter can readily receive “shifted” interpretations when embedded under attitude predicates. For example, (42) can be uttered in a context in which the speaker was confident that their paper would be accepted but their advisor held a more pessimistic view.

- (42) *Sensei-wa [boku-ga (dōse) SALT-ni(-nanka) tōra-nai]-to omot-te-ta rashii.*
 advisor-TOP I-NOM DŌSE SALT-DAT- NANKA pass-NEG-C think-PST seem
 ‘My advisor seems to have thought I wouldn’t possibly get accepted at SALT.’
 The advisor had a negative/pessimistic outlook.

Here, *nanka* and *dōse*’s evaluative meanings can only be read as reflecting the advisor’s stance, not the speaker’s.

The perspective shift under embedding suggests that the evaluative meanings of *nanka* and *dōse* do not satisfy “nondisplaceability” and “independence” among the set of properties that characterize expressives in (27). I repeat these properties in (43).

- (43) **Independence:** Expressive content contributes a dimension of meaning that is separate from the regular descriptive content.

Nondisplaceability: Expressives predicate something of the utterance situation.

In (42), the “judge” of the negative evaluation is the local attitude holder (i.e., the advisor), and hence this meaning component pertains to what is reported by the sentence rather than the utterance situation. Nor is this meaning component “independent” in the sense of (43) since it receives a “local accommodation” interpretation similar to presuppositions embedded under attitudes, as in (44) (= (26) above) .

- (44) *Hanako-wa Jon-ga kono aida mata korona-ni nat-ta-to*
 Hanako-TOP John-NOM the other.day again COVID-DAT become-PAST-COMP
omot-te-iru.
 think-PROG
 ‘Hanako thinks that John got COVID again the other day.’

Further corroboration for the fact that the evaluative meanings of outlook markers are more tightly integrated into the “utterance-situation independent” aspects of meaning comes from interactions with modal judgments. As shown in (45), when *nanka* occurs in modal judgments, the type of modality involved affects the nature of the negative evaluation meaning, reflecting the way in which truth judgment of modal sentences is itself based on stance-dependent subjective opinions.

- (45) a. *Konna tokoro ni nihonjin-nanka inai hazu da.*
 such place LOC Japanese-NANKA exist-NEG supposed COP
 ‘There shouldn’t be any Japanese people in a place like this.’
- b. *Watashi ni-wa kin medaru-nanka torenai.*
 I DAT-TOP gold.medal-NANKA get-POT-NEG
 ‘There’s no way I can win a gold medal.’
- c. *Tookyoo-ni-nanka ika-nai hō-ga yokat-ta.*
 Tokyo-DAT-NANKA go-NEG way-NOM good-PST
 ‘It would have been better not to go to Tokyo (of all places).’
- d. *Aisu kuriimu-nanka iranai.*
 Ice.cream -NANKA need-NEG
 ‘I don’t want such a thing as ice cream.’

What is interesting about these examples is that the nature of the negative implications are somewhat different depending on the type of modality involved. Intuitively, the deontic and bouletic (wishing, wanting) modality examples (45c,d) seem to evoke negative (almost pejorative) implications much more clearly as compared to the epistemic and ability modal examples in (45a,b), which tend to give rise to a somewhat more neutral interpretation.

This is arguably due to the interactions of meaning between modal predicates and outlook markers. In modal statements involving epistemic likelihood and ability as in (45a,b), truth judgment is based on one’s assessment of supporting evidence (such as the typical behavior of the Japanese in (45a) and the nature of the competition in (45b), among other things). People may, of course, have different opinions on such matters, and **that is** how truth judgment variability arises, but still, these factors can be assessed on more or less neutral grounds. By contrast, in the deontic and bouletic modal judgments in (45c,d), the relevant factors are more subjective, reflecting different understandings of social norms, moral standards, or different personal preferences and desires, etc. Signaling a conflict in the latter type of judgment inevitably evokes a confrontational tone since it amounts to a speech act in which the speaker deliberately indicates that they disagree with the proposed outlook on matters which, in principle, cannot be resolved by aligning factual understandings.

Further corroboration for interactions between the evaluative meanings of outlook markers and propositional contents of sentences comes from the fact that different outlook markers often come with different restrictions on the type of modality they are compatible with. For example, as shown in (46), *semete* ‘at least’ can occur with priority modals such as the desiderative *-tai* and the deontic *-beki*, whereas it is not compatible with epistemic and ability modals such as *hazu* and *-eru*.

- (46) a. ??Kono-yoona tokoro-ni-wa **semete** Nihonjin-wa iru hazu-da.
 this-like place-LOC-TOP at.least Japanese.top exist should-COP
 ‘In a place like this, there should at least be some Japanese people.’
 b. ??Watashi-ni-wa **semete** dō-medaru-wa toreru.
 I-DAT-TOP at.least bronze-medal-TOP obtain.can
 ‘As for me, I can at least win a bronze medal.’
 c. **Semete** yobō-sesshu-wa uke-tai.
 at.least vaccination-TOP receive-want
 ‘One should at least get vaccinated.’
 d. **Semete** ryohi-wa harau-beki-da.
 at.least travel.expenses-top pay-should-COP
 ‘At least we should cover the travel expenses.’

What does all this tell us about the nature of the evaluative meanings of outlook markers? One thing that seems clear is that this meaning component is derived from the way the speaker (or some attitude holder) recognizes the relationship between the subjective judgment embodied in the prejacent and some counterstance salient in the discourse. An important consequence that follows from this is that the similarities and differences between outlook markers and expressives follow naturally. The two have the properties “descriptive ineffability” and “immediacy” in common essentially because they both pertain to the meta-level aspects of linguistic communication. Being meta-level effects tied to specific linguistic expressions, they cannot be paraphrased by descriptive words. The difference between outlook markers and expressives also follows naturally: the two differ from each other in terms of “independence” and “nonreplaceability” since they are different types of meta-level devices. Expressives are linguistic devices for invoking certain effects in the utterance situation. By contrast, outlook markers operate at a more abstract level that is more closely integrated into the dynamic context-update potentials of utterances: they serve to govern the flow of discourse by signalling the status of the prejacent with respect to the current context-update candidates in the discourse.

Thus, what may initially appear to be complex properties of outlook markers fall out naturally from their fundamental properties as meta-level devices for discourse management. They are essentially a special type of discourse markers.⁵ Kubota and Ido (2026a,b) formulate

⁵See Zeevat (2004) in this connection, where he uses the term “context marker” for a class

analyses of *nanka* and contrastive *wa* as outlook markers embodying this idea within a model of discourse that can deal with dynamic negotiations of outlooks among interlocutors. Specifically, they build on Farkas and Bruce's (2010) Table model for dealing with discourse update with pending issues, and combine it with Coppock's (2018) outlook-based semantics for the treatment of subjectivity. The discourse function of *nanka* in Kubota and Ido's (2026b) analysis is essentially that of a counterstance marker, in that it imposes a constraint on the prior discourse that a contextually salient "counterstance" is at issue, and that the speaker's own stance embodied in the prejacent is incongruent with this counterstance as a subjective judgment. An important consequence of this approach is that the "dual" nature of outlook markers (having a presuppositional meaning component and a CI-like meaning component) falls out from its basic function as a (counter-)stance marker, without the need to separately stipulate the two meaning components in their lexical entries. See Kubota and Ido (2026b) for a full defense of this line of analysis.

Research on secondary meanings has until now primarily focused on items that display sensitivity to discourse state exclusively (prototypical presupposition triggers) or items that reflect the speaker's subjective stance or attitude irrespective of discourse state (prototypical expressives). Little attention has been paid to elements that simultaneously embody both types of meaning. Outlook markers are interesting in this context since they not only exhibit both aspects of secondary meaning, but the way they do so reflects the very essence of natural language discourse: negotiation among interlocutors about agreeable discourse update. That is, speakers **do not** necessarily just refer to the previous context, nor do they merely express subjective attitudes. The way they refer to the discourse state for the purpose of proposing update often reflects fundamentally subjective stances, and outlook markers are nothing other than devices that indicate such subjective stances explicitly. In this sense, studying outlook markers is indispensable for clarifying the fundamental structure of natural language discourse.

4 Conclusion

Among Japanese adverbs and focus particles, a distinct group of items can be identified which express a certain kind of subjective evaluation and which serve to indicate abstract discourse strategies. In this chapter, I referred to these discourse markers as "outlook markers." After a review of the relevant discussions in the formal semantics/pragmatics literature pertaining to "secondary," or "non-at-issue," meanings, we examined the secondary meanings of outlook markers in some detail. This revealed that these expressions embody two interrelated aspects: a presuppositional component that imposes a certain condition on the prior discourse, and an expressive-like meaning component that embodies the speaker's stance in situating the utterance

of discourse markers with a broadly similar characterization. Zeevat includes the additive particle *too* in his class of context markers. The term "outlook marker" in Kubota and Ido's (2026a,b) work is restricted to items that clearly have stance-dependent "subjective" meanings. Whether (certain uses of) additives should be included in the class of outlook markers in Kubota and Ido's sense is a subtle and complex issue that I cannot address properly here.

content with respect to the prior discourse.

Aside from evaluative adverbs and particles in Japanese, potential candidates for outlook markers include particles and adverbs in other languages such as German (e.g., *doch* (Egg 2013; Repp 2013), *überhaupt* (Rojas-Esponda 2014)) and Hindi (e.g., *=to* (Deo 2022)) and scale-sensitive expressions (e.g., *even* (Greenberg 2018), *at least* (Biezma 2013; Chen 2024), *almost/barely* (Horn 2017)). There is already extensive research on these items in the literature, and they are known to have implications for many central theoretical issues in the formal semantics literature (such as focus/polarity sensitivity, scalarity and modality/speech acts). But analyzing them from the perspective of discourse management of subjective stances, along lines suggested in Kubota & Ido (2026a,b), may offer a new outlook on the nature of these items and on the proper architecture of a theory of natural language discourse.

Acknowledgement

I have benefited enormously from a long-term collaboration and many conversations with Misato Ido on the analysis of focus particles in Japanese. This paper is single-authored only because a tight deadline made co-authorship difficult; in substance, however, it owes a great deal to her ideas and feedback. I would also like to thank Yurie Hara and Yoko Hasegawa, who have read and commented on the pre-final version of this paper. This work is supported by JSPS KAKENHI 24K03857, 25K00464 and the NINJAL collaborative research project “Evidence-based Theoretical and Typological Linguistics,” and was carried out at the Advanced Language Science (E3P) Research Center at NINJAL.

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